arrangement that has inevitably been accompanied by constant speculation of a handover of the baton midway through the Congress's five-year tenure. However, unlike the Grand Old Party's awkward experiences previously in states such as Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh, the power duo in Karnataka has so far been careful not to unsettle what has been the party's strongest showing in the state in three decades. With 137 MLAs, the ruling party is sitting pretty in the 224-member assembly.

A mutually cordial working style is evident between both leaders, says a senior officer, with Shivakumar deferring to the CM at meetings while the latter reciprocates by ensuring that the deputy is kept in the loop on decisions. While neither broaches the touchy topic of a change of guard, periodic comments by MLAs and ministers have kept speculation alive through these past 18 months. However, on December 4, in a television interview, Shivakumar referred to an 'understanding' which, he said, the Congress top brass was aware of. Siddaramaiah, on the other hand, has denied any such 'agreement' for a handover of power. In the event, the Hassan rally went off without a hitch with Shivakumar declaring that he would stand 'like a rock' behind Siddaramaiah. "It's my nature to be sincere in whatever task I am given," Shivakumar said at the rally.

By most accounts, the bypoll victories have come as a shot in the arm for Siddaramaiah whose political plank comprising the minorities, backward classes and Dalits—known in Kannada by the acronym AHINDA, which stands for *alpasankyataru, hindulidavaru mattu dalitaru*—was a significant factor in the Shiggaon and Sandur seats. "Beset with allegations, Siddaramaiah was looking for some signal of public perception from the ground. With the bypolls, he has got that," says a close aide. However, leader of the Opposition in the assembly R. Ashoka says the bypoll results are not a 'clean chit' to the CM given that the MUDA inquiry is still underway.

TOP OF THE AGENDA

The CM has pressing matters to attend to, especially in moving beyond the welfare guarantees. "The first priority is to take up Bengaluru city development," says Siddaramaiah. The government has indicated a roadmap to spend Rs 1.31 lakh crore on infrastructure projects in the city, which will include 100 km of elevated corridors, 80 km of additional metro lines under Phases 3 and 3A, the Bengaluru Business Corridor, a 40-km underground urban tunnel touted as India's longest, and an observation tower or 'sky deck'. The latter two proposals have run into opposition from urban activists and sustainability experts who argue that the funds can be better utilised for smaller and more impactful projects. The tunnel roads and sky deck are estimated to cost Rs 40,000 crore and Rs 500 crore, respectively.

A senior official points out the other areas that require immediate attention, among them rural infrastructure and a better targeting of the five welfare guarantees, which cover 45 million beneficiaries at present. But for any capital-inten-

INTERVIEW

"No project has been stopped due to welfare schemes"

Close on the heels of the Congress's bypoll sweep in Karnataka, Chief Minister SIDDARAMAIAH speaks to INDIA TODAY's RAJ CHENGAPPA and AJAY SUKUMARAN on his government's achievements, challenges and priorities. Edited excerpts of the interview:

Q. Talks of you sharing this tenure with D.K. Shivakumar, with each getting two and a half years, have resurfaced. Was there any such pact?

A. There is no such agreement. But we will go by whatever decision the high command makes.

Q. Where does the MUDA land allotment case against you stand?

A. Where is the case, what is my role? See, it [land] was denotified in 1998. In 2004, it was purchased by my brother-in-law. There was a partition in the family. The property—Survey No. 464 [measuring three acres and 16 *guntas*]—was gifted by my brother-in-law in 2010 and all have signed... another brother-in-law and my mother-in-law. Now, this issue has been raised...I have no role at all. There are no orders, no oral instructions, no telephonic talk with the officers.... It is only politically motivated...the BJP and JD(S) are making an issue out of a non-issue.

Q. You were CM during 2013-2018. What is the difference between your first term and now?

A. There is not much difference, because in the first regime, we implemented 158 of the 165 promises we had made. This time also, we are implementing all our programmes.

Q. What's been the main achievements in the one and a half years that you have been in power?

A. In May 2023, in the first cabinet meeting itself, we took a decision to implement all five guarantees we had promised during the election. The Shakti